

May to June, Yugoslavia and Greece in the spring of 1941, and the Soviet Union as far as the outskirts of Moscow by the end of that year. These German victories were, to an important degree, triumphs of air power. It was not until later in the war that the awesome destructive capacity of strategic bombing, imaginatively envisaged in the 1930s, would become a reality. But from the outset air power held the balance between victory and defeat. A country beaten in the air found its army and navy fighting at a hopeless disadvantage. The only serious setback that the Germans experienced in the first two years of the war was the failure to subdue Britain – a direct result of the Luftwaffe's inability to establish air supremacy over southern England in 1940.



STUKA PILOT

A German dive-bomber pilot sits in the cramped confines of his two-man cockpit – the rear gunner covered his back, and the aircraft.

German dominance

The dominance of the Luftwaffe early in the war was not simply a result of overwhelming superiority of numbers or high quality of equipment. Luftwaffe methods could be very unsophisticated – during the bombing of Warsaw, Ju 52 crews scattered incendiaries over the city by shoveling them out of the airplane's side door. In the early days of the war, Messerschmitt Bf 109s were not even equipped with radios, so the pilots communicated with one another by wagging their wings. But the Luftwaffe pilots'

training and numerical and technical superiority gave them a clear edge over their opponents. And, above all, German tactics were supremely well judged in the direction of air power to affect the course of battle.

The experience of the Battle of France, in May to June 1940, came as a profound shock to British and French airmen and their commanders. Expecting a long-drawn-out contest in the manner of the Western Front in 1914–18, they found themselves outfought and outthought, facing abject defeat in a matter of days. The Germans achieved air superiority from the outset, destroying Allied aircraft by attacks on airfields, the effective deployment of flak guns, and air combat. German commanders with a firm grasp of the principle of concentration of force assigned substantial numbers of aircraft to key points on the battlefield, so that British and French airmen, scattered in "penny packets" along the front, were overwhelmed. The Allies' problems were compounded by the inferior performance of many of their machines. Aircraft such as the RAF's Fairey Battle light bomber and the French Morane-Saulnier M.S.406 fighter proved little more than cannon fodder for the Luftwaffe's

AGENTS OF BLITZKRIEG

During the lightning offensives of the early years of the war, Junkers Ju 87 Stuka dive bombers like these operated as flying artillery in support of the German panzers. Despite their fearsome reputation, Stukas were slow and vulnerable to enemy fighters.

